

LISTEN TO THE PULL

PUSH VS. PULL

The Compass

A short guide for telling the difference

The Push vs. Pull Compass

Push and Pull can look identical from the outside. Both get you moving. You say yes before you've thought it through. You sign up for a program that feels scary. You finally make the call you've been avoiding. But they're sourced from two different places — and your body usually knows the difference before your mind catches up.

This is what “listen to the Pull” means, in practice: a way of noticing where your signal is coming from, and what happens when you follow it.

What Push Sounds and Feels Like

Push is movement sourced from outside you — from what you should be doing, what conventional “wisdom” would have you do, what unexamined habits you've inherited.

It sounds like:

- I should...
- I have to...
- I just need to figure it out.
- I can't waste any more time on this.
- I just need to make myself do it.

Underneath it, there's usually some mix of pressure, urgency, self-doubt, impatience, and an authoritative voice demanding to be followed.

Push is the voice that tries to convince you it knows best, when in reality it's running on fear.

That's different from the final push to get a project across the finish line. It's different from doing something hard on purpose — walking into a networking event in stride, stepping outside your comfort zone because you chose to. Push, here, is narrower than that: it's the voice that mistakes fear for certainty.

What Pull Sounds and Feels Like

Pull is movement sourced from inside you — from curiosity, a spark, a sense of aliveness, something that has your attention and won't quite let you go, even before you can explain why.

It sounds like:

- I'm curious about this...
- Something about this has my attention.
- I don't know why, but I want to explore it.
- I keep getting this feeling that...
- I don't know yet — and maybe I don't need to, yet.

Pull rarely shows up as certainty. More often it's curiosity, a quiet spark, or the sense that something is shifting before you can name what.

That's not squirrel bling — chasing whatever's shiniest in the moment. It's not (usually) impulsive action either. And it's not comfort-seeking: Pull can point somewhere scarier than where you started, not just somewhere easier.

It doesn't promise a quick payoff, either — trusting it doesn't mean you get immediate confirmation that it's working. And it's not avoidance wearing a disguise. Sometimes “something else has my attention” is just dodging the hard thing in front of you, and that's worth being honest about too.

Push and Pull, Side by Side

PUSHING	THE PULL
Action from externalized authority and conditioned striving.	Movement sourced in relationship with your own Knowing.
<i>Often shows up as pressure, anxiety, impatience.</i>	<i>Often shows up as curiosity, spark, aliveness.</i>

Examples:

PUSHING	THE PULL
Saying yes to something because it looks great on paper.	Saying yes because you genuinely want to see what happens.
Picking the option everyone would call sensible.	Following the one that feels like rainbows and light, even when it makes no sense yet.
Forcing yourself through a plan you no longer believe in just to finish it.	Letting yourself drop it, even without a full explanation yet.

This is the discernment that mattered most at my own biggest crossroads: the “sensible” choice felt like a dark hallway, and the one that scared me more felt like rainbows and light. Once you can tell the two apart in the moment, you get to choose on purpose — instead of finding out afterward which one was driving.

Listening Isn't the Same as Waiting

Here's the part that's easy to miss: Pull isn't passivity. It isn't sitting around waiting to be struck by inspiration before you're allowed to move.

Pull works like this — you notice something. You take a small, real step toward it. You pay attention to what that step teaches you. Then you take the next one.

Notice. Explore. Experiment. Discover. Respond.

The step isn't proof you already know where this is going. It's how you find out. Action becomes a way of gathering evidence, not just the execution of a decision you'd already made.

Naming the Pull matters. Testing it against something real is what makes it useful.

Notice It

How I experience PUSHING:

How I experience a PULL:

Try It On

Pick a current situation and run it through both lenses.

Name a situation:

What in it feels like Pushing?

What Pulls have you sensed around it?

What could shift to have less Push and more Pull?

I'm passionate about this work because I lost touch with this signal completely — gave my authority away to someone else, and it took years of trying things and exploring to find my way back to it. This exercise is that same small practice: not fixing anything, just getting honest about where the signal's coming from. That alone is what changes what you do next.

About Shawn



Hi, I'm Shawn. I didn't arrive at this philosophy by studying it — I arrived at it by living it, more than once.

At 41, I sold almost everything I owned and became a digital nomad with no plan past the first stop in Mexico, because something had my attention and I trusted it before I could explain why.

None of the turns in my life since have come from a five-year plan.

I'm just getting started with this particular chapter — writing these ideas down, testing them, building something out of what I've lived. No five-year plan here either — just the next step, and the one after that.